



IT'S SPORT AGAINST THESE PEOPLE

THE MATCH-FIXING TASK FORCE (2011)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Sports law

BEFORE

1919 Baseball team Chicago White Sox are bribed to throw the World Series, sending shock waves across the US.

2010 A confidential FIFA report leaked to the press suggests some friendly games were fixed in the run-up to the World Cup.

2011 Istanbul police arrest 60 people on suspicion of match fixing in Turkey.

AFTER

2013 Alleged match-fixing syndicate leader Dan Tan is arrested by Singapore police.

2014 The Council of Europe Convention on the Manipulation of Sports Competitions is signed; it comes into force in September 2019.

2016 Tennis star Novak Djokovic claims he was asked to throw a match in 2007.

Sports in all its forms has long been associated with betting. And the potential for illegal gambling activities to damage the integrity of sports has always been a threat.

However, attempts to tackle that threat took a new turn in 2011, when INTERPOL (the International Criminal Police Organization) established its Match-Fixing Task Force (IMFTF). The reason was simple: sports had become a vast global business that was increasingly vulnerable to systematic efforts to cheat. One

long-standing method of cheating was to induce competitors to deliberately “throw” (lose) a game so that the result of any sporting event could be determined in advance. Criminal gambling organizations could reap vast rewards in this way, placing bets on the basis of inside information. INTERPOL described such match fixing as a trillion-dollar industry. If sports were to retain its integrity, eradicating such corruption had become essential.

Global networks

The epicenter of illegal betting syndicates is Southeast Asia, where many sports are accused of corruption, with team owners, referees, and players all implicated.

From about 2010, the Asian syndicates turned their attention to the global stage. Although sports played by individuals are easier to fix than team sports, the latter are prime targets because their global popularity generates so many bets. One example was the Pakistan cricket team, with two of its players found guilty of deliberately bowling no-balls at predetermined moments during a Test match in 2010. This practice of fixing a specific aspect



The involvement of organized crime in the manipulation of sports competitions makes this phenomenon a global threat to the integrity and ethics of sport.

The Council of Europe, 2019

